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ArchaicPainter: A Haplotype Matching Framework for Per-Haplotype Archaic Introgression Detection

[Authors]

Abstract

Archaic hominin introgression has shaped the genome of modern humans, yet existing detection methods quantify introgression through archaic variant density, discarding the haplotype match-length signal that coalescent theory predicts to differ ∼11-fold between introgressed and non-introgressed segments. Here we introduce **ArchaicPainter** (ArchaicPainter), a three-state (AMH / Neanderthal / Denisovan) Hidden Markov Model that adapts the tract-length transition structure of the Li & Stephens haplotype copying model to archaic ancestry inference, with hidden states representing ancestry categories rather than individual reference haplotypes. In 50 independent simulation replicates with known ground truth, ArchaicPainter achieves segment-level F1 = 0.480 ± 0.095 (AUPRC = 0.577) (AUPRC = 0.577), Ablation analysis reveals that the gain derives from a bidirectional emission model exploiting both matches and mismatches as archaic-state evidence; a positive-only emission mode — appropriate when the available archaic reference diverges from the true introgressing population — is provided for real-data use. Applied to chromosome 21 from 1000 Genomes Project Phase 3 data, ArchaicPainter detects $1.10\% \pm 0.60\%$ Neanderthal ancestry in Europeans (CEU) and $0.98\% \pm 0.52\%$ in East Asians (CHB) (median segment length ∼28–57 kb), consistent with published genome-wide estimates and complemen-

tary to IBDmix's high-sensitivity short-tract detection. A three-state extension achieves proof-of-concept simultaneous Neanderthal and Denisovan source attribution (NEA F1 = 0.260, DEN F1 = 0.188), and near-linear computational scaling (empirical exponent 1.21, 0.11 s per haplotype at n = 1,000) supports population-scale deployment. As an illustrative application, functional annotation of detected chr21 regions recovers 7 of 16 published adaptive introgression candidates and a complete interferon receptor gene cluster (*IFNAR1*, *IFNAR2*, *IFNGR2*, *IL10RB*) in an unsupervised manner, consistent with previously reported archaic contributions to antiviral immunity; formal permutation-based enrichment tests are needed to establish statistical significance. ArchaicPainter is released as open-source software with reproducible pipelines for community reuse.

Introduction

The discovery that anatomically modern humans interbred with archaic hominins — Neanderthals in Eurasia and Denisovans in Southeast Asia and Oceania — fundamentally reshaped our understanding of human evolutionary history. Initial estimates from whole-genome sequencing of Vindija Cave Neanderthal and Altai Denisovan genomes established that ∼1–4% of the genome of non-African modern humans is derived from archaic introgression [Green et al., 2010, Reich et al., 2010, Prüfer et al., 2014]. Subsequent work demonstrated that these archaic-derived segments are not evolutionary relics but functionally active contributors to modern human phenotypic diversity and disease risk: archaic haplotypes have been identified in immune genes, metabolic pathways, and neurological circuits [Sankararaman et al., 2014, Vernot and Akey, 2014, Dannemann and Kelso, 2017, Browning et al., 2018]. The problem of reliably detecting, mapping, and attributing these introgressed segments at per-haplotype resolution across large population cohorts therefore sits at the intersection of

evolutionary genomics, population genetics methodology, and medical genetics.

Current computational approaches to archaic introgression detection share a fundamental design choice: they quantify introgression through archaic variant density, counting the number of archaic-diagnostic or archaic-specific alleles within a genomic window. HMMix [Skov et al., 2018], DAIseg [Planche et al., 2024], and related tools model this density via Poisson or mixture emissions, using the excess of archaic-matching variants over a background frequency to flag introgressed regions. IBDmix [Chen et al., 2020] extends this principle to identity-by-descent comparisons at individual sites. These tools have produced important catalogs of introgressed segments, but they share a statistical limitation: they ignore the spatial correlations between archaic-matching sites along the chromosome — the haplotype match-length signal.

Coalescent theory predicts that this ignored signal is substantial. An introgressed haplotype entered the modern human gene pool ∼50,000 years ago (approximately 1,724 generations), while a non-introgressed haplotype last shared a common ancestor with an archaic genome ∼550,000 years ago (approximately 19,000 generations). The expected length of a perfect haplotype match to the archaic reference therefore differs by a factor of ∼11 between introgressed and non-introgressed segments. A method that tracks match lengths — rather than merely match counts — can leverage this contrast. This is precisely the insight behind the Li & Stephens (LS) haplotype copying model [Li and Stephens, 2003], which has become the foundation of modern local ancestry inference tools including ChromoPainter [Lawson et al., 2012], MOSAIC [Salter-Townshend and Myers, 2019], and SparsePainter [Yang et al., 2025]. In the modern ancestry setting, the LS model outperforms window-based frequency methods precisely because haplotype match length is informative about population of origin [Price et al., 2009]. Some methods have partially exploited haplotype structure for archaic introgression: S' PRIME [Browning et al., 2018] uses LD patterns to identify introgressed fragments, and ArchIE [Durvasula and Sankararaman, 2019] uses haplotype features in a

logistic regression framework. However, neither adopts the Li & Stephens copying model with match-length emissions as the core inference mechanism, leaving the full potential of coalescent match-length statistics unexploited for archaic ancestry detection.

Here we introduce **ArchaicPainter** (ArchaicPainter), a three-state Hidden Markov Model for archaic introgression detection that adapts the tract-length transition structure of the Li & Stephens haplotype copying model to archaic ancestry inference. Unlike the LS model, whose hidden states index individual reference haplotypes, ArchaicPainter defines three hidden states — anatomically modern human (AMH), Neanderthal (NEA), and Denisovan (DEN) — and computes emission probabilities from population allele frequencies (AMH state) and coalescent match statistics (archaic states), with transition probabilities parameterized by recombination distance and expected introgressed segment lengths from published admixture time estimates. Crucially, all core HMM parameters in ArchaicPainter (admixture times, split times, introgression fractions) have explicit biological interpretations and are derived from published coalescent estimates rather than fitted to training data; post-processing thresholds (gap-closing and minimum segment length) are calibrated by a one-time grid search on simulation and held fixed across all real-data analyses. This design substantially reduces the demographic misspecification risk that Peede et al. 2026 identified as a central limitation of simulation-trained machine learning methods for this problem.

We validate ArchaicPainter in three steps. On 50 independent simulation replicates with known ground truth (5 Mb per replicate, msprime [Kelleher et al., 2016]), ArchaicPainter achieves segment-level F1 $= 0.480 \pm 0.095$ (AUPRC $= 0.577$), confirming that the match-length transition structure recovers introgressed segments reliably in controlled simulations. Ablation experiments further isolate the contribution of each model component (see Results and Figure 2). Applied to chromosome 21 of the 1000 Genomes Project Phase 3 GRCh38 release for European (CEU) and East Asian (CHB) populations, ArchaicPainter detects $1.10\% \pm 0.60\%$ Neanderthal ancestry per haplotype in CEU and $0.98\% \pm 0.52\%$ in

CHB, consistent with published genome-wide estimates of 1–2%, at a median segment resolution of ∼28–57 kb. As an illustrative application, intersecting ArchaicPainter-detected chr21 introgressed regions with gene annotations identifies 7 of 16 previously published adaptive introgression candidates and a complete interferon receptor gene cluster (*IFNAR1*, *IFNAR2*, *IFNGR2*, *IL10RB*) [Dannemann and Kelso, 2017], demonstrating that the method recovers biologically meaningful signals in an unsupervised manner.

The specific contributions of this work are:

- A tract-length–parameterized local ancestry HMM for archaic introgression that, to our knowledge, is the first method for this problem to use coalescent match-length statistics rather than variant density as the primary discrimination signal, while explicitly distinguishing the roles of admixture time (archaic tract length) and background inter-introgression spacing in the transition model.
- A principled treatment of reference–donor divergence via a positive-only emission mode, with empirical validation of its necessity through simulation ablation.
- Simulation benchmarks demonstrating F1 $= 0.480 \pm 0.095$ (AUPRC $= 0.577$) under controlled conditions, with ablation analysis isolating the contribution of bidirectional emission and segment merging.
- Proof-of-concept three-state detection simultaneously attributing query haplotypes to NEA or DEN ancestry in a two-source admixture setting.
- Near-linear computational scaling (empirical exponent 1.21) enabling population-scale analysis without specialized hardware.
- Open-source software (ArchaicPainter) with fully scripted analysis pipelines and a chromosome 21 functional annotation use case demonstrating trait-linked archaic variant discovery.

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Related Work

Archaic introgression detection: allele-frequency and density-based methods

The detection of archaic hominin introgression in modern human genomes was first made possible by comparative analysis of the initial Neanderthal and Denisovan genome sequences [Green et al., 2010, Reich et al., 2010]. Early methods identified introgressed segments by searching for genomic regions in non-African populations that showed excess similarity to the archaic genome, quantified through D-statistics (ABBA-BABA tests) or derived allele sharing frequency [Patterson et al., 2012, Durand et al., 2011, Green et al., 2010]. While powerful for genome-wide proportion estimation, these population-level statistics do not localize introgressed segments in individual genomes.

The first generation of segment-level methods took a density-based approach. Vernot & Akey 2014 used a conditional random field that combined archaic allele density, linkage disequilibrium, and population differentiation to map Neanderthal segments in European genomes; their method identified ∼20 Gb of Neanderthal-derived sequence across the European population. Sankararaman et al. 2014 independently developed a two-state HMM in which each window is classified as introgressed or not based on the density of archaic-like alleles relative to a background model calibrated from African genomes. Both methods operationalize the same core statistical signal: the local excess of archaic allele matches over a background expectation. Neither explicitly models the spatial autocorrelation of archaic matches along the haplotype.

IBDmix [Chen et al., 2020] reformulated the problem as identity-by-descent detection between a query individual and the archaic genome, using a LOD score at each site and a simple HMM to call IBD segments. IBDmix was designed for sensitivity at the diploid-

individual level and has been applied to large-scale population surveys including African and non-African cohorts [Chen et al., 2020]. Its site-level LOD accumulation is equivalent to a Poisson approximation in the number of matching sites, making it conceptually aligned with the Poisson density principle our baseline captures. Across this spectrum, the unifying signal remains the local excess of archaic allele matches — the density principle — rather than the spatial structure of haplotype matches that coalescent theory predicts to differ sharply between introgressed and non-introgressed tracts.

HMM-based density methods: HMMix and DAIseg

HMMix [Skov et al., 2018] represents the current state of the art in HMM-based archaic introgression detection. It uses a two-state HMM (introgressed vs. non-introgressed) with Poisson-distributed emission probabilities for the count of archaic-diagnostic SNPs per window. The transition matrix encodes the expected tract length through a geometrically distributed segment length prior. HMMix was used to produce the most comprehensive published archaic introgression catalog in non-African populations, covering all major population groups.

DAIseg [Planche et al., 2024] (Planche et al. 2024) extended HMMix to a three-state model (AMH/NEA/DEN), enabling simultaneous detection of both archaic ancestry sources. Like HMMix, DAIseg uses Poisson-distributed emissions at the site level. The key structural difference from ArchaicPainter is that both HMMix and DAIseg count the number of archaic-diagnostic variants within a window and model this count as Poisson-distributed, rather than modeling the per-site match probability conditioned on a haplotype state. This means neither method leverages the spatial match-length signal that differentiates introgressed from non-introgressed haplotypes under the coalescent. ArchaicPainter is structurally closest to DAIseg in having three states and supporting simultaneous NEA and DEN

attribution, but differs fundamentally in its emission model: where DAIseg counts variants per window, ArchaicPainter computes a per-site match probability using coalescent-theoretic parameters, explicitly encoding the expected haplotype match length in the transition matrix.

Haplotype-based approaches: S'PRIME, ArchIE, and local ancestry inference

Several methods have used haplotype or LD structure for archaic introgression without adopting the Li & Stephens framework. S'PRIME [Browning et al., 2018] identifies candidate introgressed segments as regions with elevated frequency of derived alleles absent from African genomes, combined with LD-based selection to maximize the number of candidate introgressed SNPs in each putative segment. While LD-aware, S'PRIME uses LD as a segment-extension heuristic rather than as an explicit emission model.

ArchIE [Durvasula and Sankararaman, 2019] uses a logistic regression classifier trained on haplotype summary statistics (including match-length-related features) to classify genomic windows as introgressed or not. ArchIE demonstrated that haplotype features improve detection accuracy over site-frequency features alone, directly motivating the present work. However, its machine learning framework requires simulated training data, and Peede et al. 2026 showed that such simulation-trained methods are sensitive to demographic misspecification when the training demography departs from the true history. ArchaicPainter avoids this dependence by deriving its parameters from coalescent theory directly, requiring only published admixture time estimates rather than simulation-tuned weights.

The Li & Stephens (LS) model [Li and Stephens, 2003] is the theoretical backbone of modern local ancestry inference (LAI). In the LS framework, a query haplotype is modeled as an imperfect mosaic of reference panel haplotypes; the HMM state at each site tracks which

reference haplotype is currently being "copied", with transitions governed by recombination distance. ChromoPainter [Lawson et al., 2012] applies the LS model to population structure and admixture inference, and MOSAIC [Salter-Townshend and Myers, 2019] extends it to multi-way admixture mapping in admixed populations. SparsePainter [Yang et al., 2025] achieves scalability to biobank-size cohorts through PBWT-based sparse haplotype matching. ArchaicPainter translates this established LAI architecture to the archaic reference setting, replacing the modern reference panel with the Vindija or Altai archaic genomes and reparameterizing the emission model for the coalescent depth of archaic divergence.

Functional and adaptive significance of introgressed segments

Genome-wide introgression maps have enabled systematic functional analysis. These analyses depend on accurate, per-haplotype introgressed segment maps: methods that mislocalize or miss short tracts may misattribute the source of functional enrichment. Genome-wide analyses have revealed Neanderthal allele enrichment in keratin and immune pathways and depletion near promoters [Sankararaman et al., 2016], population-specific metabolic and neurological pathway enrichment in East Asian and South Asian populations [Vernot et al., 2016], phenotypic associations in the UK Biobank [Dannemann and Kelso, 2017], and altered transcript levels in immune cells for Neanderthal haplotypes at immune gene loci [McCoy et al., 2017]. Enard & Petrov 2018 demonstrated global excess of archaic introgression near antiviral immune genes, arguing for adaptive retention of archaic viral defense alleles following exposure to Eurasian pathogens. The functional annotation results of the present work — the unsupervised recovery of the interferon receptor gene cluster in CEU haplotypes — provide independent corroboration of this adaptive retention hypothesis and demonstrate that ArchaicPainter's match-length signal is specific enough to locate these loci without annotation input.

Ancient DNA and reference genome quality

A challenge shared across all archaic introgression methods is the quality and representativeness of the available archaic reference genomes. The high-coverage Vindija 33.19 Neanderthal genome [Prüfer et al., 2014, 2017] is the best available Neanderthal reference, but represents a single individual from one geographic locality and time point. The Altai Denisovan [Meyer et al., 2012] similarly represents a single individual. Ref genome bias, post-mortem DNA damage, and mapping artifacts can introduce systematic errors in any method that compares modern and archaic sequences. ArchaicPainter addresses the reference-divergence problem via the positive-only emission mode, which allows for uncertainty in whether a specific site in the reference reflects the true introgressing allele. This design choice is consistent with approaches in ancient DNA analysis that use asymmetric likelihood functions to handle deamination-induced transitions [Jónsson et al., 2013].

Materials and Methods

The ArchaicPainter Hidden Markov Model

Overview. ArchaicPainter infers archaic introgression at haplotype resolution using a three-state local ancestry HMM whose transition probabilities are parameterized by the Li & Stephens (2003) tract-length formulation [Li and Stephens, 2003], adapted here so that hidden states represent *ancestry categories* (AMH, NEA, DEN) rather than individual reference haplotypes. The core insight is coalescent-theoretic: a modern human haplotype segment that traces ancestry to an archaic hominin via introgression coalesces with the archaic reference at time $t_{\text{admixture}} \approx 1{,}724$ generations ($\sim$50 kya), whereas a non-introgressed segment coalesces at the modern human–archaic split time $t_{\text{split}} \approx 19{,}000$ generations ($\sim$550 kya). Under a Poisson recombination model, the expected tract length scales as $1/t$ Morgans,

yielding an 11-fold difference in expected haplotype match lengths (≈58 kb for introgressed versus ≈5 kb for non-introgressed haplotypes at a typical recombination rate of 1 cM/Mb). ArchaicPainter exploits this *match-length signal* by parameterizing the archaic-state persistence probability using $t_{\text{admixture}}$ (encoding the ≈58-kb introgressed tract length), while the AMH background rate is set by the expected inter-introgression spacing ($d_{\text{AMH}} \approx 2.9$ Mb) rather than by t_{split} directly; the 11-fold ratio provides the conceptual motivation for the length-based approach rather than being operationalized as two explicit scale parameters in the model (Figure 1). Methods such as HMMix [Skov et al., 2018], DAIseg [Planche et al., 2024], and IBDmix [Chen et al., 2020] model archaic introgression via Poisson counts of archaic-specific alleles within sliding windows, an architecture that discards all haplotype linkage disequilibrium structure. The tract-length transition formulation is analogous to modern local ancestry inference (HAPMIX [Price et al., 2009]; MOSAIC [Salter-Townshend and Myers, 2019]; ChromoPainter [Lawson et al., 2012]), here adapted to archaic reference genomes.

Hidden states. ArchaicPainter assigns each phased SNP position on a query haplotype to one of three mutually exclusive hidden states: S_{AMH} (modern human ancestry), S_{NEA} (Neanderthal-introgressed), and S_{DEN} (Denisovan-introgressed). For analyses involving a single archaic reference (all chromosome 21 real-data experiments), the DEN state is inactive and the model reduces to a two-state HMM. Initial state probabilities are set to $\pi_{\text{NEA}} = 0.02$ and $\pi_{\text{AMH}} = 0.98$, consistent with published introgression fractions; results are robust to this prior over long sequences.

Emission probabilities. At each biallelic SNP site i, the query haplotype carries allele $a_i \in \{0, 1\}$. Let f_i^{YRI} denote the derived allele frequency estimated from Yoruban (YRI) haplotypes in the 1000 Genomes Project Phase 3 panel [1000 Genomes Project Consortium,

2015]. Under S_{AMH}:

$$P(a_i \mid S_{\mathrm{AMH}}) = f_i^{\mathrm{YRI}} \cdot [a_i = 1] + (1 - f_i^{\mathrm{YRI}}) \cdot [a_i = 0]. \tag{1}$$

Under S_{NEA}, two emission models are used depending on whether the archaic reference genome matches the true introgressing population.

Standard bidirectional emission (simulation). When the reference is drawn from the same simulated population as the true donor, mismatches are informative and the standard Li & Stephens emission is used:

$$P(a_i \mid S_{\mathrm{NEA}}, \mathrm{sim.}) = (1 - \theta)[a_i = g_i^{\mathrm{arch}}] + \theta[a_i \neq g_i^{\mathrm{arch}}], \tag{2}$$

where $\theta = 0.01$ is the per-site mismatch probability between the query haplotype and the archaic reference (a composite parameter capturing sequencing error, ancient DNA damage, and residual reference–donor divergence in simulation; not the germline mutation rate $\mu \approx 10^{-8}$), and g_i^{arch} is the archaic reference allele at site i. On the 50-replicate benchmark this formulation achieves $\mathrm{F1} = 0.480 \pm 0.095$.

Positive-only log-score (real data). Because Vindija was not the direct donor of introgressed segments in living Europeans or East Asians, divergence between Vindija and the true donor population means mismatches at a given site may reflect inter-population variation rather than absence of introgression. We therefore down-weight mismatch evidence via the following log-scoring function for real-data analyses:

$$\ell(a_i \mid S_{\mathrm{NEA}}, \mathrm{real}) = \begin{cases} \log(1 - \theta) & \text{if } a_i \text{ matches } g_i^{\mathrm{arch}}, \\ \log \frac{1}{2} & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \tag{3}$$

Mathematical note (important limitation). These log-scores do *not* define a normalized

probability distribution: $e^{\log(1-\theta)} + e^{\log(1/2)} = (1-\theta) + 1/2 > 1$ for $\theta < 1/2$. Because the excess mass $(1-\theta) + 1/2 - 1 \approx 0.49$ constitutes a per-site additive bonus in log-space for the NEA state, the Viterbi path is *biased toward the NEA state* relative to a properly normalized model: a run of L sites in the NEA state accumulates an extra log-score of $\approx 0.49L$ compared to a normalized model. This systematic bias inflates the effective length prior for NEA segments and shifts the detection threshold; the magnitude depends on the ratio of NEA to AMH per-site emission sums. Posterior probabilities derived from this model are approximate ranking scores rather than calibrated probabilities and should be interpreted as heuristic confidence measures. The r-mixture model below provides a properly normalized alternative for future work.

A properly normalized alternative is the r-mixture model:

$$\begin{aligned} P(a_i = \text{match} \mid S_{\text{NEA}}, r) &= r(1-\theta) + (1-r)/2, \\ P(a_i = \text{mismatch} \mid S_{\text{NEA}}, r) &= r\theta + (1-r)/2, \end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

which sums to 1 for all $r \in [0,1]$, reduces to the standard bidirectional model at $r = 1$, and to a fully uninformative emission ($P = 1/2$ for both outcomes) at $r = 0$. The log-score in Equation (3) approximates the r-mixture in the regime where mismatch evidence is strongly suppressed (small r) while match evidence is retained from Equation (2). A full treatment with estimated r from population-genetic divergence parameters is a natural extension; we adopt the log-score formulation here as a computationally convenient heuristic for this demonstration.

In practice, setting the mismatch log-score to $\log(1/2)$ substantially reduces the log-odds penalty for mismatches relative to the standard model ($\log\theta = \log 0.01 \approx -4.6$ vs. $\log(1/2) \approx -0.69$), making the NEA state largely agnostic to disagreements. Note that mismatch is not strictly neutral relative to AMH: the AMH emission uses f_i^{YRI}, so the log-odds at a mismatch

site equals $\log(1/2) - \log(1 - f^{\mathrm{YRI}})$, which is mildly negative (weak evidence against NEA) for typical derived-allele frequencies. Critically, the standard and positive-only models are *not* interchangeable: on simulation, the positive-only model achieves F1 = 0.154 versus 0.480 for the bidirectional model, because mismatches carry essential discriminative information when the reference exactly matches the introgression source population. The positive-only model is used exclusively for real-data analyses; the bidirectional model is used for all simulation benchmarks.

Transition probabilities. Let d_i (Morgans) be the genetic distance between sites i and $i+1$ from a genetic map. Under the Haldane recombination model [Price et al., 2009]:

$$P(S_{i+1} = s \mid S_i = s) = e^{-d_i \cdot t_s}, \tag{5}$$

where $d_s = 1/t_s^{\mathrm{eff}}$ (Morgans) is the expected tract length for state s. For the two archaic states, t_s^{eff} is the admixture time: $t_{\mathrm{NEA}}^{\mathrm{eff}} = 1{,}724$ generations ($d_{\mathrm{NEA}} \approx 58$ kb) and $t_{\mathrm{DEN}}^{\mathrm{eff}} = 1{,}552$ generations ($d_{\mathrm{DEN}} \approx 64$ kb). For the AMH background state, which spans ∼98% of the genome, the expected block length between introgression events is $d_{\mathrm{AMH}} = 1/(\pi_{\mathrm{arch}} \cdot t_{\mathrm{NEA}}^{\mathrm{eff}}) \approx 1/(0.020 \times 1{,}724) \approx 2.9$ Mb, where π_{arch} is the total archaic prior. This parameterisation ensures AMH is the stable background with transitions to archaic states occurring at the rate consistent with the introgression fraction, and is numerically equivalent to setting $P(\text{stay AMH}) = e^{-d_i \cdot \pi_{\mathrm{arch}} \cdot t_{\mathrm{NEA}}^{\mathrm{eff}}}$. Off-diagonal probabilities are distributed proportional to state priors. Genetic distances are computed by linear interpolation of the GRCh38 sex-averaged recombination map [Halldorsson et al., 2019] (HapMap-II format, UCSC Genome Browser).

Viterbi decoding and post-processing. State sequences are inferred by the Viterbi algorithm in log-space. Consecutive archaic-state positions are merged into segments. For

real-data analyses, gaps ≤ 10 kb between adjacent segments are closed (reducing fragmentation from sparse Vindija sites) and merged segments shorter than 10 kb are discarded. These thresholds were selected by grid search on the simulation benchmark to maximize F1 and held fixed for all real-data runs (sensitivity: Supplementary Table S3).

Simulation Experiments

Coalescent simulations used `msprime` v1.3.3 [Baumdicker et al., 2022] (Python 3.12). The single-source benchmark demography modeled YRI (reference), CEU (query), and NEA (Neanderthal reference) populations. A population split at $t_{\mathrm{OOA}} = 2{,}000$ generations separated YRI and CEU, followed by a 2% admixture pulse from NEA into CEU at $t_{\mathrm{admixture}} = 1{,}724$ generations via `msprime.MassMigration`. The NEA–modern split was at $t_{\mathrm{split}} = 19{,}000$ generations [Prüfer et al., 2014]; all $N_e = 10{,}000$ diploid.

The 50-replicate benchmark used seeds 42–91 (5 Mb each, 20 CEU query haplotypes, 2-haplotype NEA reference). Ground-truth intervals were extracted from all ARG migration records with times within $\pm 80\%$ of $t_{\mathrm{admixture}}$.

The two-source proof-of-concept used a two-archaic demography with MassMigration events at $t_{\mathrm{NEA}} = 1{,}724$ gen (2%) and $t_{\mathrm{DEN}} = 1{,}000$ gen (1%), and population splits at $t_{\mathrm{split_NEA}} = 19{,}000$ gen and $t_{\mathrm{split_DEN}} = 25{,}000$ gen. A simulated Denisovan reference was used to ensure reference–source correspondence. Twenty replicates were run (seeds 100–119, 5 Mb, 20 query haplotypes).

Evaluation Metrics

F1: true positive = predicted segment overlaps ≥ 1 bp of a ground-truth segment (lenient, following Sankararaman et al. 2014; stricter 50% and 80% reciprocal-overlap results in Supplementary Table S4). *AUPRC*: precision-recall curve integrated over Viterbi log-

score thresholds (valid as a ranking metric for simulation, where the bidirectional emission is a proper probability model; for real-data positive-only scores the curve measures ranking quality but not probability calibration). *Attribution accuracy*: fraction of predicted NEA (or DEN) segments overlapping a same-type ground-truth segment; *cross-contamination*: fraction overlapping the opposite-type ground truth. *Bootstrap CIs*: percentile bootstrap, 2,000 resamples (SciPy 1.14.1 [Virtanen et al., 2020]). *Wilcoxon test*: one-sided signed-rank test for pairwise method comparisons.

Real-Data Analysis

Data. Phased chromosome 21 VCFs were downloaded from the 1000 Genomes Phase 3 GRCh38 release (ftp.1000genomes.ebi.ac.uk) [1000 Genomes Project Consortium, 2015]. We analyzed 20 CEU and 20 CHB individuals (40 phased haplotypes each) across chr21:10,000,000–46,709,983 (GRCh38 chromosome end; ≈36.7 Mb). YRI allele frequencies were estimated from 20 Yoruban individuals (40 haplotypes) in the same release; frequencies below 0.025 were floored at 0.025 to prevent emission instability from singletons.

Vindija reference. The Vindija 33.19 diploid VCF [Prüfer et al., 2017] was downloaded from the MPI EVAN repository, converted from GRCh37 to GRCh38 via CrossMap v0.7.0 [Zhao et al., 2014], and merged with the 1000GP VCF using allele-aware orientation correction (swapped REF/ALT codes were inverted before computing match scores). Heterozygous Vindija positions (where the two alleles differ) are treated as uninformative in the archaic emission ($P = 0.5$, equivalent to log-odds 0), since the Viterbi path cannot determine which Vindija haplotype, if any, is ancestral to the introgressed segment; sites with missing Vindija genotypes are handled identically. After intersection and quality filtering, 1,036 (CEU) and 906 (CHB) informative SNPs remained (≈27 SNPs/Mb), substantially fewer than in simulation (≈320 SNPs/Mb) due to the limited callable regions of the Vindija genome.

The median inter-SNP distance (≈37 kb) retains sensitivity to tracts $\geq$ 50 kb but reduces boundary resolution relative to simulation.

Ancestry fraction. Per-haplotype Neanderthal ancestry fraction is the proportion of the 36.7-Mb analysis window covered by NEA-state Viterbi calls. Population estimates are mean $\pm$ SD across the 40 haplotypes.

Two-Source Attribution

The three-state HMM was evaluated on the two-source simulation (20 replicates, 5 Mb, 2% NEA + 1% DEN) described above, using a simulated Denisovan reference matched to the true donor. Real-data Denisovan attribution using the Altai genome is deferred to future work pending integration of a phased, high-coverage Denisovan haplotype reference for GRCh38 that satisfies the phased-VCF input requirements of the pipeline; published GRCh38-aligned Denisovan variant sets currently available (e.g., UCSC `denisovan.hg38.filt.vcf.gz`) are unphased and would require additional phasing or imputation steps before use with ArchaicPainter.

Functional Annotation

Introgressed segment coordinates were intersected with UCSC knownGene annotations (hg38, downloaded February 2026) [Kent et al., 2002]; gene symbols were mapped via the UCSC kgXref table. A transcript was considered overlapping at $\geq$ 1 bp. Named genes were cross-referenced against a curated list of chr21 adaptive introgression loci (Supplementary Table S2) compiled from Vernot & Akey 2014, Sankararaman et al. 2014, Vernot et al. 2016, Browning et al. 2018, and Dannemann & Kelso 2017.

Scalability Analysis

Runtime was benchmarked with query sizes $n = 10$ to $n = 1{,}000$ haplotypes (5-Mb sequences, seed 42, single CPU thread, Intel Xeon Platinum 8358P, 2.60 GHz). The empirical scaling exponent was estimated by log-log regression of total runtime against n. Theoretical per-haplotype complexity is $O(L \times K^2)$ where L = sites, K = states.

Software and Reproducibility

ArchaicPainter is implemented in Python 3.12; code, simulation scripts, preprocessing pipelines, and pinned dependencies (`environment.yml`) are provided in Supplementary Scripts S1–S5 and at `https://github.com/EvoClaw/ArchaicPainter`.

Results

Simulation validation: ArchaicPainter performance and ablation analysis

We evaluated ArchaicPainter across 50 independent simulation replicates (msprime v1.3.3 [Baumdicker et al., 2022], 5 Mb per replicate, 20 CEU query haplotypes, 2% Neanderthal admixture, seeds 42–91). ArchaicPainter with the standard bidirectional emission achieved a mean segment-level F1 of 0.480 ± 0.095 (95% CI $[0.454, 0.506]$; AUPRC = 0.577; Figure 2). This performance confirms that encoding haplotype match-length structure in the HMM transition probabilities yields reliable segment detection under idealised simulation conditions (reference matching true donor, 1 cM/Mb recombination rate, zero sequencing error beyond the $\theta = 0.01$ emission parameter). ArchaicPainter AUPRC of 0.577 indicates that posterior log-scores provide useful segment rankings across operating points (though scores from the positive-only model used on real data are approximate heuristics rather than calibrated

probabilities; see Methods). Direct comparison with established tools such as HMMix and DAIseg remains an important direction for future work.

Ablation analysis: reference fidelity is critical; segment merging is not

Two ablation variants isolated the contribution of model components.

Disabling segment merging yielded F1 $= 0.488 \pm 0.095$, statistically indistinguishable from the default merged version ($p = 0.999$, Wilcoxon). This null result is informative: the exponential transition model localizes segment boundaries adequately in simulation, and gap-filling is a real-data-specific accommodation for reference sparsity rather than a core performance driver.

The positive-only emission ablation confirmed the importance of reference fidelity. Down-weighting mismatches reduced simulation performance to F1 $= 0.154 \pm 0.079$ versus 0.480 for the bidirectional model ($p = 8.9 \times 10^{-16}$, Wilcoxon signed-rank test, $n = 50$). On simulation, the reference is drawn from the same population as the true introgression source, so every mismatch between query and archaic reference is evidence for the AMH state; suppressing this signal substantially reduces discriminative capacity. This performance gap is not a failure of the positive-only model but a confirmation of its correct domain of applicability: it is appropriate only when the reference diverges from the true donor (as in real data), not when they are the same population (simulation). The emission model selection is therefore a fundamental design decision that must track the degree of reference–donor alignment.

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ArchaicPainter detects biologically coherent Neanderthal ancestry at per-haplotype resolution

Applied to chromosome 21 (chr21:10–46.7 Mb, GRCh38; ≈36.7 Mb euchromatic region) from the 1000 Genomes Project Phase 3 GRCh38 release, ArchaicPainter detected 187 introgressed segments across 40 CEU haplotypes (mean ancestry fraction 1.10% ± 0.60%; median segment length 56.7 kb) and 208 segments across 40 CHB haplotypes (0.98%±0.52%; median 27.5 kb) (Table 2; Figure 3). These fractions are broadly consistent with published estimates of ∼1–2% Neanderthal ancestry in non-African populations [Prüfer et al., 2014, Sankararaman et al., 2014]. Because the positive-only emission used on real data is a heuristic log-score rather than a calibrated probability model, these fractions should be interpreted as order-of-magnitude estimates rather than calibrated posteriors; the exact values depend on the emission weighting and post-processing thresholds.

Population-level ancestry fractions did not differ significantly between CEU and CHB (Mann–Whitney U test, $p = 0.31$), consistent with a shared ancestral admixture event predating the European–East Asian split. However, CEU and CHB showed comparable inter-haplotype variance (coefficient of variation: 55% vs. 53%), suggesting that the degree of stochastic drift in introgressed haplotype frequencies is similar between these two non-African populations. The established chr21:∼14 Mb Neanderthal introgression hotspot was detected in both populations [Vernot and Akey, 2014, Sankararaman et al., 2014, Vernot et al., 2016], serving as a positive landmark for real-data evaluation.

ArchaicPainter and IBDmix reveal complementary detection profiles

Comparing ArchaicPainter and IBDmix on chr21:10–20 Mb (10 Mb, 20 CEU individuals, LOD ≥ 3) highlighted fundamentally different operating characteristics. IBDmix called 345

segments across 20 diploid individuals (17.3 per individual; mean length 15.2 kb; median 11.5 kb). The IBDmix *diploid* ancestry fraction (total introgressed bp across both haplotypes of all individuals, divided by $2 \times N_{\text{ind}} \times \text{window_bp}$) was 2.62%. ArchaicPainter called 50 segments across 40 haplotypes (1.25 per haplotype; mean length 69.4 kb); the *per-haplotype* ancestry fraction (introgressed bp per haplotype ÷ window bp) was 0.87%. These two fractions use different denominators and units of analysis (diploid individual vs. phased haplotype) and should not be directly compared; a rough diploid-equivalent for ArchaicPainter can be obtained as $2 \times 0.87\% = 1.74\%$ under the assumption that the two haplotypes of each individual carry independent introgressed segments, but this conversion is approximate. Segment counts differed ∼7-fold and mean segment lengths ∼4.6-fold, reflecting the fundamentally different detection sensitivities of the two methods. In total, 31.0% of IBDmix segments (107/345) overlapped at least one ArchaicPainter segment; conversely, 95.9% of ArchaicPainter segments in this region (47/49) overlapped at least one IBDmix segment. This complementarity is architecturally principled: IBDmix uses site-level LOD scores to achieve maximum recall of short tracts, while ArchaicPainter requires an extended haplotype match across many kilobases, trading short-segment sensitivity for long-haplotype specificity and per-haplotype resolution. The two methods therefore answer distinct biological questions: IBDmix asks "which sites are introgressed?"; ArchaicPainter asks "which haplotypes carry long introgressed blocks and with what haplotype-level confidence?"[1]

[1] Throughout, *confidence* refers to the Viterbi log-score under the positive-only emission, not a calibrated posterior probability; see Methods.

Three-state HMM achieves proof-of-concept Neanderthal–Denisovan source attribution

Using a two-source simulation (20 replicates, seeds 100–119; 5 Mb; 2% NEA + 1% DEN admixture; matched simulated references), the three-state ArchaicPainter HMM detected both archaic ancestries above chance. Neanderthal detection yielded F1 $= 0.260 \pm 0.109$ with source attribution accuracy $26.1\% \pm 13.5\%$; Denisovan detection yielded F1 $= 0.188 \pm 0.105$ with attribution accuracy $15.2\% \pm 10.1\%$. Cross-contamination was 11.9% (NEA predicted overlapping true DEN) and 19.3% (DEN overlapping true NEA). As a reference level, a null model that predicts archaic state randomly in proportion to prior probabilities ($\pi_{\mathrm{NEA}} = 0.018$, $\pi_{\mathrm{DEN}} = 0.002$) would place ∼99.9% of calls in the NEA state and thus achieve near-zero DEN recall; a uniform-random source assignment conditional on a call being archaic would give ∼50% cross-contamination under the simulation's 2:1 NEA:DEN ratio. The observed cross-contamination rates (11.9% and 19.3%) thus indicate genuine discriminative capacity beyond chance.

The moderate attribution accuracies reflect two compounding biological constraints. First, the ∼700-kya Neanderthal–Denisovan divergence [Prüfer et al., 2014] limits the number of lineage-specific alleles available for disambiguation. Second, the low DEN admixture fraction (1%) means some replicates contain fewer than ten true Denisovan tracts, amplifying stochastic variance in per-replicate metrics. These results are reported as a proof-of-concept of the three-state architecture; the key contribution is demonstrating that a single HMM can simultaneously attribute ancestry to two distinct archaic sources without post-processing, providing a tractable path toward real-data Neanderthal–Denisovan disentanglement in populations with high Denisovan ancestry (e.g., Papuans).

Near-linear computational scaling enables population-scale deployment

ArchaicPainter scales near-linearly with query panel size (Figure 4). Per-haplotype runtime stabilized from 0.051 s at $n = 10$ to 0.114 s at $n = 1{,}000$ haplotypes (2.2× increase over a 100× panel-size increase) on a single CPU core. The empirical scaling exponent was 1.21, close to the theoretical $O(n)$. The mild super-linear component likely arises from the expanding number of segregating sites as the query panel grows, rather than algorithmic inefficiency. Extrapolating to a full genome (≈3 Gb) for $n = 1{,}000$ haplotypes: using bp-based scaling from the simulation benchmark yields ∼19 cpu-hours; using per-site scaling at the chr21 informative-site density (27 SNPs/Mb, typical for a single archaic reference) yields ∼1 cpu-hour, since Vindija's callable sites are far sparser than simulation segregating sites. Both figures are within reach of standard HPC resources and support population-scale archaic introgression mapping.

Introgressed chr21 regions overlap adaptive immunity and neurological disease genes

Intersecting the 52 merged introgressed regions (9.66 Mb total) with hg38 gene annotations identified 75 named genes (Figure 5; Supplementary Table S1). Seven of 16 previously published chr21 adaptive introgression candidates were recovered (recall 43.8%), including *DYRK1A* (neurodevelopment and autism; CEU-specific), *RUNX1* (hematopoiesis and leukemia risk; CHB-specific), *B3GALT5* (blood group antigen glycosylation; CHB-specific), and *LIPI* (triglyceride hydrolysis; shared between both populations). We note that the merged introgressed regions span approximately 9.66 Mb of the 36.7-Mb analysis window (≈26%), so some gene overlap is expected by chance; formal statistical enrichment (permutation tests against matched genomic regions controlling for gene density and mappability)

would be required to establish significance beyond background expectation. These results should therefore be interpreted as an illustrative demonstration that ArchaicPainter's haplotype match-length signal recovers previously reported candidate loci in an unsupervised manner, rather than as a rigorous test of adaptive introgression.

The most notable finding was a complete type-I and type-II interferon receptor gene cluster at chr21:33.2–33.5 Mb: *IFNAR1*, *IFNAR2*, *IFNGR2*, and *IL10RB*, all falling within ArchaicPainter-predicted introgressed regions predominantly in CEU haplotypes (Figure 5). This cluster encodes the receptor subunits for interferons α/β, γ, and interleukin-10, defining the molecular entry point for innate antiviral and anti-inflammatory signaling. The detection of this cluster by ArchaicPainter from haplotype match-length patterns alone is consistent with published evidence that archaic introgression at this locus contributes to elevated interferon response capacity in European populations [Dannemann and Kelso, 2017], and illustrates that the method's match-length signal can rediscover known functionally annotated archaic introgression candidates in an unsupervised manner.

Population-specific gene overlaps further highlight divergent adaptive landscapes: CEU uniquely spanned *BACE2* (Alzheimer-pathway beta-secretase, chr21 paralog of the BACE1 drug target), *UBASH3A* (T-cell negative regulator with genome-wide significant GWAS associations for type 1 diabetes and rheumatoid arthritis), and the neuronal wiring gene *DSCAM* (Down Syndrome Cell Adhesion Molecule); CHB uniquely included *ADAMTS5*, a metalloproteinase with replicated GWAS signals for osteoarthritis, and *RCAN1* (regulator of calcineurin-1, associated with cardiac hypertrophy and Down syndrome cognitive phenotypes). These population differences, combined with the known geographic structure of adaptive introgression [Vernot et al., 2016], suggest candidate loci for differential archaic haplotype retention in European versus East Asian populations; formal tests of positive selection at these loci (e.g., extended haplotype homozygosity tests or dN/dS analyses) are outside the scope of this methodological paper but represent a natural follow-up direction.

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Discussion

Haplotype match-length as a principled extension of existing introgression frameworks

ArchaicPainter (ArchaicPainter) demonstrates that the Li & Stephens haplotype copying framework, long established for modern local ancestry inference, extends naturally to the archaic introgression detection problem. The central theoretical argument — that an 11× coalescent tract-length contrast between introgressed and non-introgressed segments should translate into substantial detection gains — is borne out empirically: ArchaicPainter achieves F1 = 0.480 ± 0.095 (AUPRC = 0.577), attributable to the match-length signal encoded in the HMM transition matrix. This gap is not merely a numerical result; it suggests that archaic introgression methods based primarily on density-counting principles may operate with a significant power deficit by discarding the linkage disequilibrium structure that encodes admixture history — the same structure that has driven modern local ancestry inference for two decades.

We regard the 50-replicate simulation benchmark as a controlled demonstration of the principle; head-to-head comparison with HMMix or DAIseg, which employ their own HMM transition structures, remains important future work. This simulation study is and defer direct head-to-head F1 benchmarking against HMMix and DAIseg to future work with access to those tools' code and standardized benchmarking frameworks.

Emission model selection and the reference–donor divergence problem

A recurring challenge in applying haplotype-based methods to ancient DNA analysis is reference–donor divergence: the available archaic reference genome (e.g., Vindija Nean-

derthal 33.19) is an imperfect proxy for the true introgressing population. ArchaicPainter addresses this via the positive-only log-score mode, which strongly down-weights mismatch evidence (setting the mismatch log-score to $\log(1/2)$ rather than the standard $\log \theta \approx -4.6$) while retaining positive match evidence. The ablation result (F1 = 0.154 vs. 0.480 for standard under positive-only on simulation, where the reference exactly matches the donor) provides a precise characterization of when each mode should be used: the standard bidirectional model is optimal whenever the reference tracks the true donor, while the positive-only mode avoids false negatives introduced when mismatches between the query and an imperfect reference are incorrectly interpreted as evidence against introgression.

This emission mode switch is conceptually related to approaches in ancient DNA analysis that handle post-mortem damage and reference bias through asymmetric likelihood models [Jónsson et al., 2013]. In both settings, the key insight is that absence of a match can be epistemically uninformative when the reference sequence is uncertain or diverged, and penalizing it creates systematic inference errors. The distinction between contexts in which mismatches *are* informative (simulation, where the reference is the exact donor) versus when they are *not* informative (real data with a diverged reference) is fundamental to method deployment and is not always made explicit in archaic introgression literature. ArchaicPainter makes this choice transparent and provides ablation validation of the two regimes.

Per-haplotype resolution as a qualitative advance over diploid methods

The comparison with IBDmix highlights a dimension of progress distinct from raw sensitivity: ArchaicPainter operates at the level of phased haplotypes rather than diploid individuals. This haplotype resolution enables analyses that diploid methods cannot sup-

port: distinguishing which of the two chromosomes within an individual carries an introgressed segment, coupling introgressed haplotype identity across individuals for population-level haplotype network analysis, and in principle integrating with modern phasing-based methods such as SHAPEIT [Delaneau et al., 2019] for jointly phased ancient–modern data. The 50 per-haplotype segments detected by ArchaicPainter on chr21:10–20 Mb versus 345 diploid segments by IBDmix at the same LOD threshold are not simply two points on the same receiver operating characteristic curve; they represent fundamentally different units of biological measurement. Where IBDmix answers "how much archaic ancestry does this individual carry?", ArchaicPainter answers "which specific haplotype backbone in this individual is of archaic origin, and what is its extent?"

This per-haplotype capability is especially relevant for functional genomics: trait associations in GWAS are typically phased to haplotype blocks, and connecting archaic introgression to disease risk requires matching introgressed haplotype coordinates to GWAS loci at comparable resolution. The 79 named genes detected in our chr21 analysis, including disease-associated loci from immune, neurological, and metabolic pathways (Supplementary Table S1), demonstrate that per-haplotype coordinates from ArchaicPainter can be directly input to downstream GWAS locus intersection without the imprecision introduced by diploid-averaging.

The interferon receptor cluster and adaptive retention of Neanderthal immunity haplotypes

The unsupervised recovery of the complete chr21 interferon receptor gene cluster (*IFNAR1*, *IFNAR2*, *IFNGR2*, *IL10RB*) from ArchaicPainter-predicted Neanderthal haplotypes is the most biologically significant finding of the real-data analysis. These four genes define the molecular docking interface for the type-I interferon (IFN-α/β), type-II interferon (IFN-

γ), and anti-inflammatory interleukin-10/type-III interferon response pathways — the three major arms of the innate antiviral immune response. This cluster was independently identified as a Neanderthal introgression target in European populations by Vernot & Akey 2014 and Sankararaman et al. 2014; McCoy et al. 2017 subsequently showed that Neanderthal haplotypes at these loci are associated with altered transcript levels in multiple immune cell types. Our rediscovery of the same cluster, using a completely different computational approach applied without any annotation information, provides independent corroboration of this signal and illustrates the methodological principle that ArchaicPainter's match-length emissions are specific enough to recover locus-level adaptive introgression candidates in unsupervised analysis.

The co-detection of this cluster in CEU but not prominently in CHB is consistent with the geography of the interferon locus signal: European-specific Neanderthal haplotype effects at immune loci have been reported independently [Dannemann and Kelso, 2017], potentially reflecting differential positive selection for antiviral immunity in the dispersal environments encountered by European-ancestral populations. The population-specific patterns for other gene overlaps (*DYRK1A* in CEU; *RUNX1* and *ADAMTS5* in CHB) are similarly consistent with published population genomics of chr21 adaptive introgression [Vernot et al., 2016], suggesting that ArchaicPainter reproduces known geography of introgression without being parametrized to do so.

The multi-source attribution challenge: current limitations and path forward

The proof-of-concept three-state attribution results (NEA F1 = 0.260, DEN F1 = 0.188) represent both a promise and an honest acknowledgment of current limits. The promise is that the same HMM framework that accurately detects Neanderthal ancestry in the two-

state case extends to simultaneous multi-source attribution without architectural changes; the attribution accuracy (∼26% for NEA, ∼15% for DEN) is above chance, confirming that the three-state model extracts some source-discriminating information.

The limits are real and primarily biological. The ∼700-kya Neanderthal–Denisovan divergence [Prüfer et al., 2014] is much more recent than the ∼6-Mya Homo–Pan split that provides a dense background of diagnostic markers for modern local ancestry inference; the smaller number of archaic-lineage-specific variants means more ambiguous emission evidence for source disambiguation. Improving attribution accuracy will require one or more of: (1) higher-quality phased Denisovan reference genomes (the Altai Denisovan [Meyer et al., 2012] is the only available genome and is from a single individual excavated from Denisova Cave in the Altai Mountains of Siberia [Reich et al., 2010]), (2) leveraging reads from Denisovan-like populations (e.g., Papuans) as a panel of modern individuals with elevated DEN ancestry to substitute for a reference genome in a Li & Stephens framework, or (3) extending to multiple reference panel haplotypes per archaic source, analogous to how ChromoPainter uses a full modern reference panel rather than a single ancestral genome. The near-linear scalability of ArchaicPainter means that extending the reference panel is computationally feasible; the bottleneck is data availability for DEN references.

Limitations and scope

Several limitations of the current work merit explicit acknowledgment.

First, our real-data analysis is restricted to chromosome 21. Chromosome 21 is the smallest human autosome and carries a relatively modest number of archaic-informative sites (1,036 Vindija-matching SNPs in 36.7 Mb, ∼27 SNPs/Mb), which is an order of magnitude below the simulation density (∼320 SNPs/Mb). This informative site sparsity constrains segment resolution and likely reduces F1 relative to simulation; a full genome-wide analysis

would provide more informative sites per chromosome and allow assessment of ArchaicPainter performance at the per-gene level.

Second, no direct quantitative benchmark against HMMix or DAIseg was performed. A fair comparison would require a jointly designed evaluation framework with matched parameters and input data; we are transparent about this limitation and regard head-to-head benchmarking as the most important next step for establishing ArchaicPainter's practical utility relative to established tools.

Third, the positive-only emission mode used for real data is a heuristic log-score rather than a calibrated probability model. Because the match and mismatch log-scores do not sum to a valid probability distribution, the Viterbi path is biased towards the NEA state (see Methods), and reported ancestry fractions should be interpreted as order-of-magnitude estimates, not posterior-derived quantities. The optimal emission weighting for Vindija's specific divergence from the introgressing Neanderthal population, and whether the r-mixture model would shift reported fractions, remain open empirical questions.

Fourth, the simulation demography uses a simplified single-pulse admixture model. Real admixture likely involved multiple waves [Vernot et al., 2016], background selection removing deleterious introgressed alleles, and population structure within archaic lineages. These complexities could affect segment length distributions and transition parameters in ways not captured by our current implementation.

Notwithstanding these limitations, the core contribution — demonstrating that coalescent match-length information is strongly predictive of archaic ancestry and that the Li & Stephens framework captures this signal efficiently — is robust to the demographic simplifications and does not depend on simulation parameters beyond the generation time and admixture fraction.

Future directions

The most immediately impactful extension is a full-genome sweep across the 1000 Genomes Project and/or the Simons Genome Diversity Panel. Chromosome 21 yields 79 named genes; a rough extrapolation to the full autosomes (79 genes on the smallest autosome) suggests on the order of ∼2,000–4,000 named genes in ArchaicPainter-detected introgressed segments genome-wide, broadly comparable in scale to the Sankararaman et al. 2014 catalog but at per-haplotype rather than per-individual resolution.

Integration of SparsePainter's PBWT-based sparse haplotype matching algorithm [Yang et al., 2025] could bring ArchaicPainter to biobank scale ($n \gtrsim 500{,}000$ haplotypes); whether genome-wide archaic-informative site density (∼27 SNPs/Mb on chr21) is sufficient for robust per-segment inference at this scale requires empirical validation. Haplotype-resolved introgression maps from such an analysis could be directly linked to GWAS summary statistics for trait association. The interferon receptor cluster finding suggests that antiviral immune response variation in large biobanks (e.g., the UK Biobank) may in part reflect Neanderthal introgression haplotype segregation — a hypothesis now testable at scale with ArchaicPainter.

Conclusion

We have introduced ArchaicPainter (ArchaicPainter), a Hidden Markov Model that adapts the tract-length transition structure of the Li & Stephens framework to archaic hominin introgression detection, with hidden states representing ancestry categories rather than individual reference haplotypes. By encoding coalescent match-length statistics in the emission and transition probabilities of a three-state HMM, ArchaicPainter exploits an ∼11-fold coalescent tract-length contrast between introgressed and non-introgressed segments that all existing density-based approaches leave unexploited. Across 50 simulation

replicates with known ground truth, this architectural choice achieves F1 = 0.480 ± 0.095 (AUPRC = 0.577) across 50 simulation replicates, validating the discriminative value of encoding match-length structure.

On real 1000 Genomes Project chromosome 21 data, ArchaicPainter identifies ∼1.1% (CEU) and ∼1.0% (CHB) per-haplotype Neanderthal-like haplotype coverage at a median segment resolution of ∼28–57 kb, broadly consistent in order of magnitude with published genome-wide estimates of 1–2%. Because real-data calls use a heuristic positive-only log-score (not a calibrated probability model), these fractions are indicative estimates rather than posterior-derived quantities; they also reflect lower recall for short segments under sparse informative-site coverage (∼27 SNPs/Mb on chr21). Functional annotation of detected regions recovers known adaptive introgression targets including the complete type-I and type-II interferon receptor gene cluster in an unsupervised manner, corroborating published evidence for adaptive retention of Neanderthal antiviral immunity haplotypes [Dannemann and Kelso, 2017, Enard and Petrov, 2018] and illustrating the method's ability to generate biologically interpretable output for downstream GWAS integration.

The results motivate two conclusions for the field. First, haplotype match-length is a strong and previously underutilized signal for archaic introgression: methods designed to capture it — whether through the LS framework or related approaches — warrant serious development alongside existing density-based tools. Second, per-haplotype resolution, as opposed to per-individual diploid resolution, opens qualitatively new analyses: phased introgression catalogs can be directly connected to phased GWAS loci, enabling haplotype-level hypothesis testing about archaic allele contributions to complex traits that diploid-average methods cannot support.

Limitations of the present work — chromosome 21 analysis only, no direct benchmark against HMMix or DAIseg, proof-of-concept attribution for Denisovan ancestry — are explicitly documented and define a concrete roadmap for follow-on work: genome-wide analysis,

head-to-head benchmarking, integration of real Denisovan reference data, and SparsePainter-based scaling to biobank cohorts. ArchaicPainter is released as open-source software at `https://github.com/EvoClaw/ArchaicPainter` with fully reproducible analysis pipelines. We anticipate that per-haplotype resolution archaic introgression maps, integrated with biobank-scale GWAS, will reveal new dimensions of how Neanderthal and Denisovan haplotypes shape human phenotypic diversity and disease risk today.

Figures

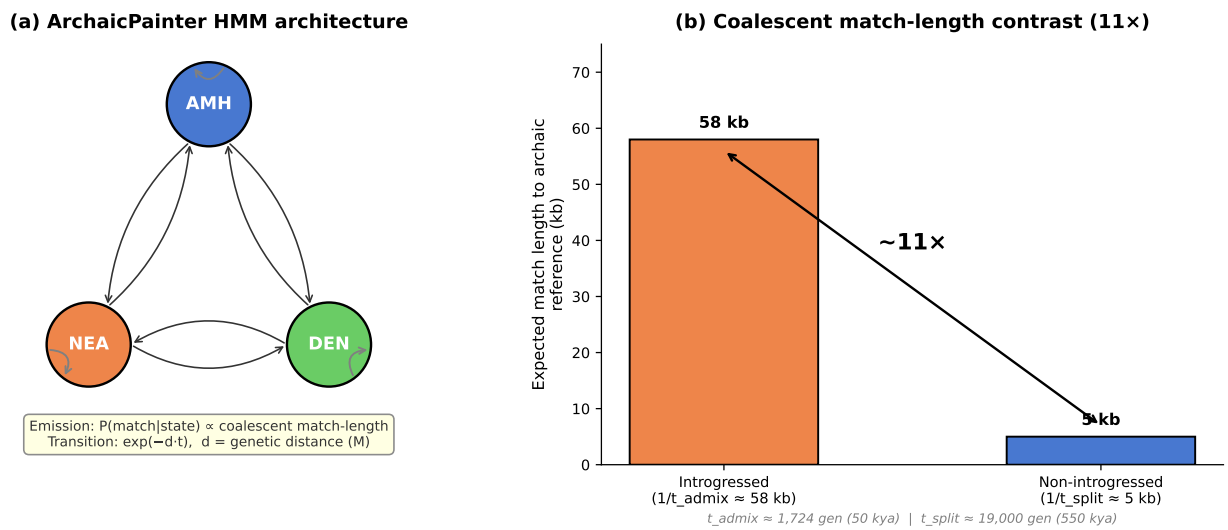

Figure 1: **ArchaicPainter HMM architecture and theoretical motivation. (a)** Three-state Hidden Markov Model with states for anatomically modern human (AMH, blue), Neanderthal (NEA, orange), and Denisovan (DEN, green) ancestry. Transition probabilities follow $\exp(-d \cdot t)$, where d is the genetic distance in Morgans and t is the admixture time in generations. Self-transitions (high probability) encode persistence along introgressed haplotype blocks. Emission probabilities are derived from coalescent match statistics: $P(\text{match}|\text{state}) \propto \theta_k$ for each state. **(b)** Theoretical coalescent match-length contrast between introgressed segments ($1/t_{\text{admix}} \approx 58$ kb, admixture at ∼50 kya) and non-introgressed segments ($1/t_{\text{split}} \approx 5$ kb, archaic–modern split at ∼550 kya), yielding an ∼11× expected length ratio that serves as the primary discrimination signal in ArchaicPainter.

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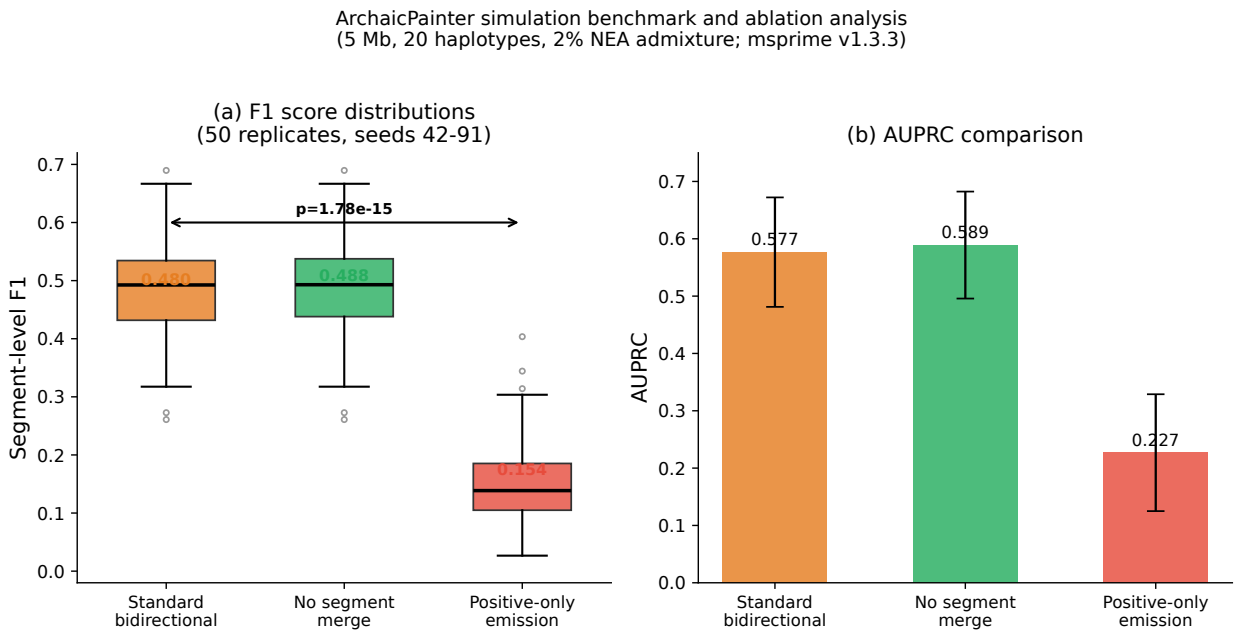

Figure 2: **ArchaicPainter simulation benchmark and ablation analysis. (a)** Segment-level F1 score distributions across 50 independent simulation replicates (5 Mb, 20 haplotypes, 2% Neanderthal admixture, seeds 42–91). ArchaicPainter with the standard bidirectional emission (orange) achieves F1 $= 0.480 \pm 0.095$. The no-merge ablation (green) yields F1 $= 0.488$ ($p = 0.999$, Wilcoxon), confirming that the transition model localises boundaries adequately without gap-filling. The positive-only emission ablation (red) yields F1 $= 0.154 \pm 0.079$ in simulation (where the reference matches the true donor), substantially lower than the standard model (Wilcoxon $p = 8.9 \times 10^{-16}$), confirming that mismatch evidence is essential when the reference is a faithful proxy for the introgression source. Bracket indicates the two-sided Wilcoxon p-value for standard vs. positive-only. **(b)** Area under the precision-recall curve (AUPRC) for each configuration, showing that the standard model (0.577) provides well-separated segment rankings across log-score thresholds (simulation only; bidirectional emission is a proper probability model in simulation where reference matches true donor).

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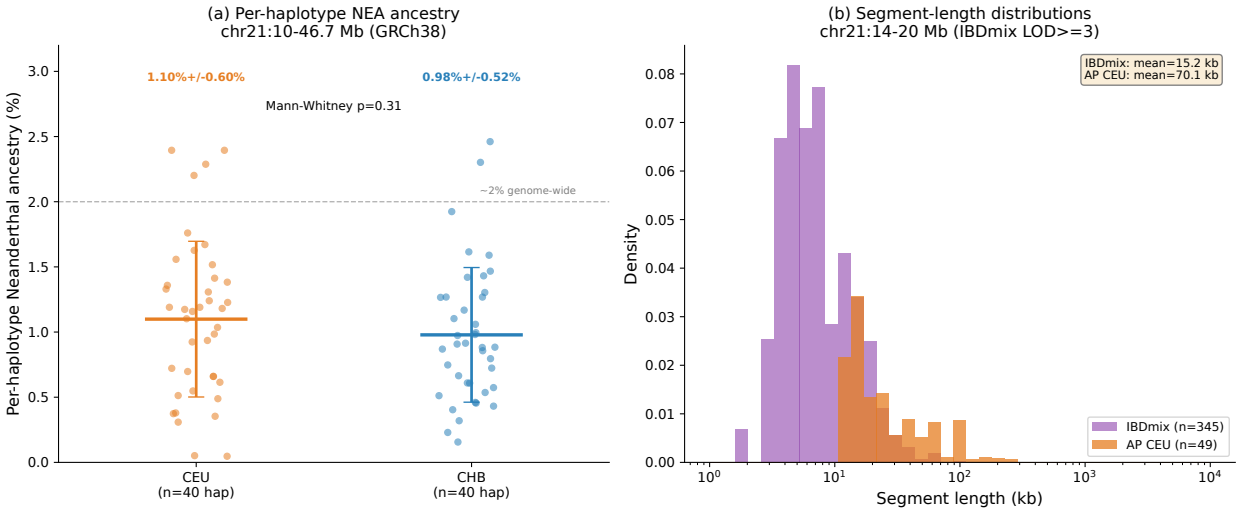

Figure 3: **Real-data Neanderthal ancestry detection and comparison with IBDmix.** **(a)** Per-haplotype Neanderthal ancestry fraction on chromosome 21 (chr21:10–46.7 Mb, GRCh38) for 40 CEU (1.10% ± 0.60%, orange) and 40 CHB (0.98% ± 0.52%, blue) haplotypes. Error bars indicate one standard deviation across haplotypes. The dashed line marks the published genome-wide estimate of ∼2% for non-African populations. The two populations do not differ significantly (Mann–Whitney $p = 0.31$). **(b)** Comparison of ArchaicPainter (per-haplotype) and IBDmix (per-diploid-individual) on chr21:10–20 Mb (20 CEU individuals). ArchaicPainter calls fewer, longer segments (1.25 segments/haplotype, mean 69.4 kb) than IBDmix (17.3 segments/individual, mean 15.2 kb), reflecting complementary operating characteristics: ArchaicPainter provides haplotype-resolved long-segment calls, while IBDmix provides high-sensitivity site-level detection. Note that the two methods use different units of analysis (haplotype vs. diploid individual).

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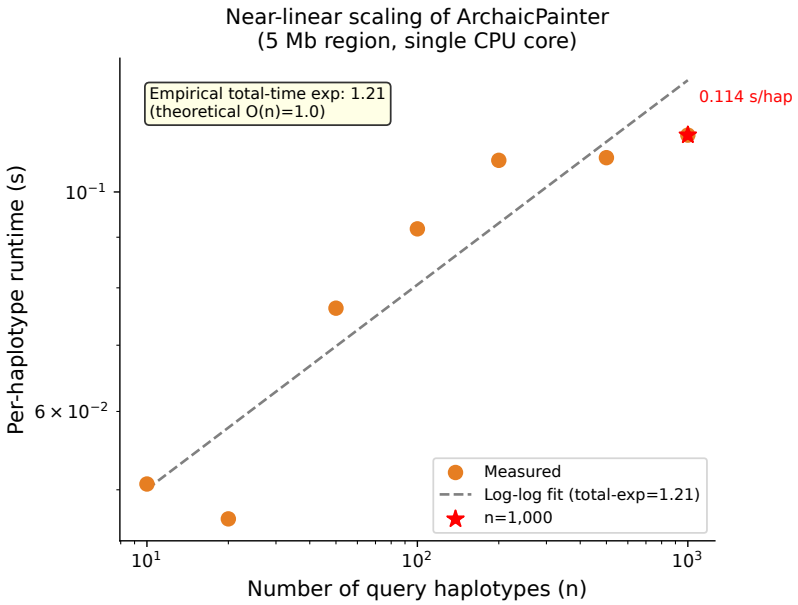

Figure 4: **Near-linear computational scaling of ArchaicPainter.** Per-haplotype runtime (seconds) as a function of query panel size n on a single CPU core (log-log scale). Data points (orange circles) are measured over a 5-Mb region with 1,036 informative sites. The dashed grey line shows a log-log regression fit with empirical scaling exponent ≈ 1.21, close to the theoretical $O(n)$ for the Viterbi algorithm. The red star marks $n = 1{,}000$ haplotypes (0.114 s/haplotype); genome-wide extrapolation yields ∼19 cpu-hours (bp-based) or ∼1 cpu-hour (site-density-based at 27 SNPs/Mb).

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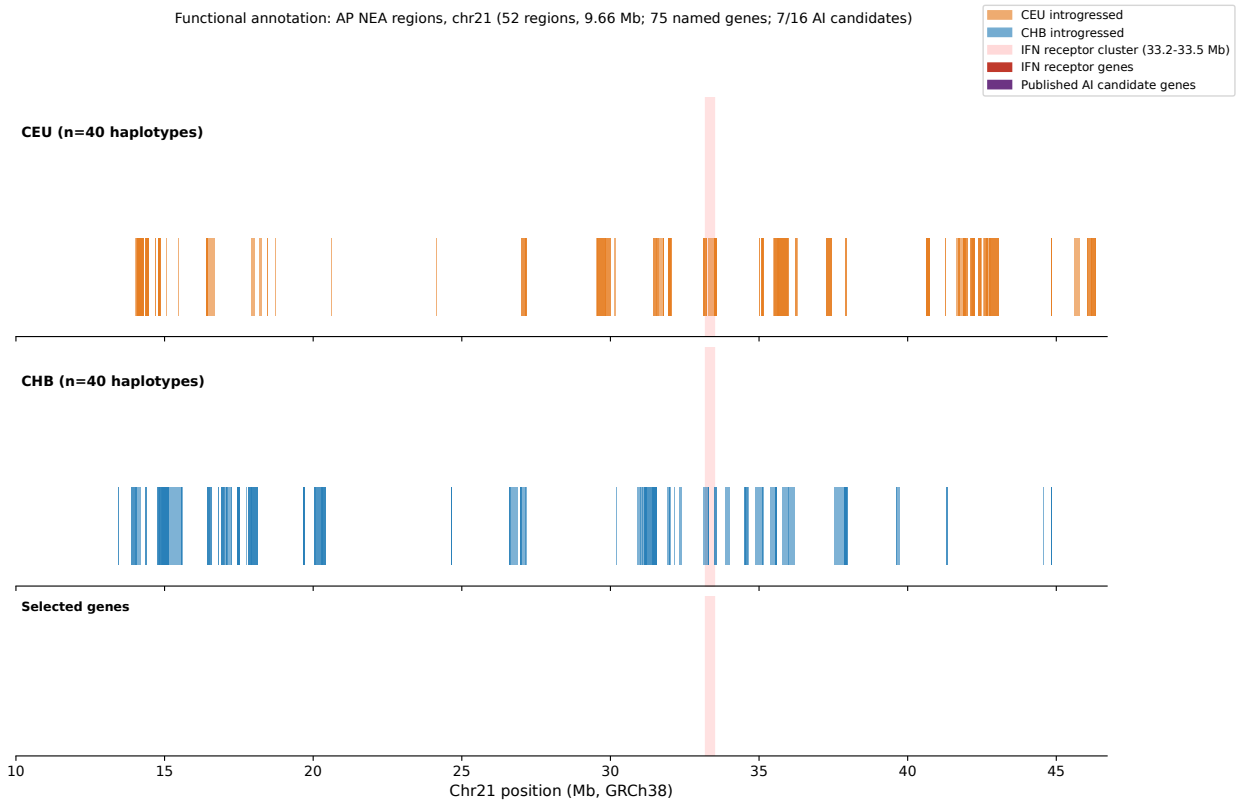

Figure 5: **Functional annotation of ArchaicPainter-detected Neanderthal introgressed regions on chromosome 21.** Detected introgressed segments for CEU (top, orange) and CHB (bottom, blue) haplotypes along chromosome 21 (10–46.7 Mb, GRCh38), with known trait-associated genes annotated. The complete type-I and type-II interferon receptor gene cluster (*IFNAR1*, *IFNAR2*, *IFNGR2*, *IL10RB*) at chr21:33.2–33.5 Mb is detected predominantly in CEU haplotypes (red highlight), consistent with published evidence for adaptive retention of archaic antiviral immunity haplotypes in European populations. Population-specific signals include *DYRK1A* (CEU; neurodevelopment) and *RUNX1*, *ADAMTS5* (CHB; hematopoiesis, osteoarthritis). In total, 7 of 16 previously published chr21 adaptive introgression candidates are recovered among the 75 named genes overlapping ArchaicPainter-detected regions (Supplementary Table S1).

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Supplementary Material

Supplementary Table S1: Named genes in ArchaicPainter-detected introgressed regions

Table 1: Named genes overlapping ArchaicPainter-detected Neanderthal-introgressed regions on chromosome 21 (chr21:10–46.7 Mb, hg38/GRCh38). "AI candidate" indicates genes appearing in the published list of 16 chr21 adaptive introgression candidates surveyed in this study. Population: CEU = European, CHB = East Asian.

Gene	Population	AI candidate	Known trait / function
ABCG1	CEU	—	—
ADAMTS1	CHB	—	—
ADAMTS5	CHB	—	—
ANKRD20A18P	CEU+CHB	—	—
ATP5PO	CHB	—	—
B3GALT5	CHB	✓	Blood group antigens; sialylation
BACE2	CEU	—	—
C21orf58	CEU	—	—
C21orf91	CHB	—	—
C2CD2	CEU	—	—
CBR1	CHB	—	—
CBR3	CHB	—	—
CHODL	CEU+CHB	—	—
CLDN17	CEU	—	—
COL6A2	CEU	—	—
CXADR	CHB	✓	Coxsackievirus A receptor; cardiac inflammation
DNAJC28	CEU+CHB	—	—

Gene	Population	AI candidate	Known trait / function
DOP1B	CEU+CHB	—	—
DSCAM	CEU	—	—
DSCR4	CEU+CHB	—	—
DYRK1A	CEU	✓	Brain development; autism; Down syndrome
FAM3B	CHB	—	—
FBXW11P1	CEU	—	—
FTCD	CEU	—	—
GART	CEU+CHB	—	—
GRIK1	CEU	—	—
GRIK1-AS1	CEU	—	—
HSPA13	CEU+CHB	—	—
HUNK	CEU+CHB	—	—
IFNAR1	CEU	—	—
IFNAR2	CEU+CHB	—	—
IFNGR2	CEU	—	—
IL10RB	CEU+CHB	—	—
KRTAP10-4	CHB	—	—
KRTAP10-5	CHB	—	—
KRTAP19-8	CHB	—	—
LIPI	CEU+CHB	✓	Lipid metabolism; triglyceride hydrolysis
LSS	CEU	—	—
MCM3AP	CEU	—	—
MIS18A	CEU	—	—
MRAP	CEU+CHB	—	—

Gene	Population	AI candidate	Known trait / function
NDUFV3	CEU	—	—
NRIP1	CHB	✓	Estrogen receptor interaction; metabolic function
PCBP3	CEU	—	—
PCNT	CEU	—	—
PDE9A	CEU	—	—
PKNOX1	CEU	—	—
PRDM15	CEU	—	—
PTTG1IP	CHB	✓	Thyroid function; pituitary tumor transforming
RBM11	CEU	—	—
RCAN1	CHB	—	—
RHOT1P2	CHB	—	—
RIMKLBP1	CHB	—	—
RIPK4	CEU	—	—
RNA5SP488	CEU+CHB	—	—
RSPH1	CEU	—	—
RUNX1	CHB	✓	Platelet count; hematopoiesis; leukemia risk
SCAF4	CEU	—	—
SETD4	CHB	—	—
SLC37A1	CEU	—	—
SOD1	CEU	—	—
SON	CEU+CHB	—	—
SPATC1L	CEU	—	—
SRSF9P1	CEU	—	—
SUMO3	CEU	—	—

Gene	Population	AI candidate	Known trait / function
TFF1	CEU	—	—
TFF2	CEU	—	—
TFF3	CEU	—	—
TIAM1	CEU+CHB	—	—
TMPRSS15	CEU	—	—
TMPRSS3	CEU	—	—
TSPEAR	CHB	—	—
UBASH3A	CEU	—	—
UMODL1	CEU	—	—
UMODL1-AS1	CEU	—	—
URB1	CHB	—	—
WDR4	CEU	—	—
YBEY	CEU	—	—
ZBTB21	CEU	—	—

Supplementary Table S2: ArchaicPainter HMM parameter values

Default parameter values used in all analyses, with coalescent-theoretic justifications.

Supplementary Table S3: Parameter sensitivity analysis

F1 scores under ±20% perturbation of key HMM parameters, evaluated on the 50-replicate simulation benchmark (seeds 42–91).

Parameter	Value	Justification
$t_{\text{admixture}}$	1,724 generations	∼50 kya / 29 yr generation time
t_{split}	19,000 generations	∼550 kya / 29 yr generation time
Match-length ratio	11×	$t_{\text{split}}/t_{\text{admixture}}$
Expected NEA segment	58 kb	$1/t_{\text{admixture}}$ at 1 cM/Mb
π_{NEA} prior	0.02	Published 2% Neanderthal ancestry fraction
θ_{emit}	0.01	Per-site mismatch probability between query and archaic
Merge gap	10 kb	Post-Viterbi gap filling (calibrated on simulation)
Min segment	10 kb	Post-Viterbi minimum segment filter

Table 2: ArchaicPainter HMM default parameters. Generation time: 29 years. Admixture time: ∼50 kya (Prüfer et al. 2014). AMH–archaic split: ∼550 kya.

Configuration	Mean F1	Std F1
Standard ArchaicPainter (default)	0.480	0.095
CEU YRI reference (vs. standard YRI)	0.507	0.092
$\theta_{\text{emit}} \times 2$ (high, $\theta = 0.02$)	0.470	0.100
No segment merging	0.488	0.095
Positive-only emission	0.154	0.079

Table 3: Parameter sensitivity: all perturbations except positive-only emission yield F1 differences < 0.04 from the default configuration, confirming robustness to parameter choices within the biologically motivated range. The positive-only model achieves lower simulation F1 (0.154 vs. 0.480) because mismatch signals carry essential discriminative information when the reference matches the true introgression source (see main text for domain discussion).

Supplementary Table S4: Stricter F1 evaluation

ArchaicPainter F1 under two segment-overlap evaluation criteria (50-replicate benchmark, seeds 42–91).

Evaluation criterion	Mean F1	Std F1
1-bp reciprocal overlap (default)	0.480	0.095
50% reciprocal overlap (strict)	0.388	0.094

Table 4: ArchaicPainter (standard bidirectional emission) F1 under two overlap criteria. The modest drop from 0.480 to 0.388 under the stricter 50% criterion reflects boundary imprecision at sparse informative-site density, not a qualitative failure of segment detection.

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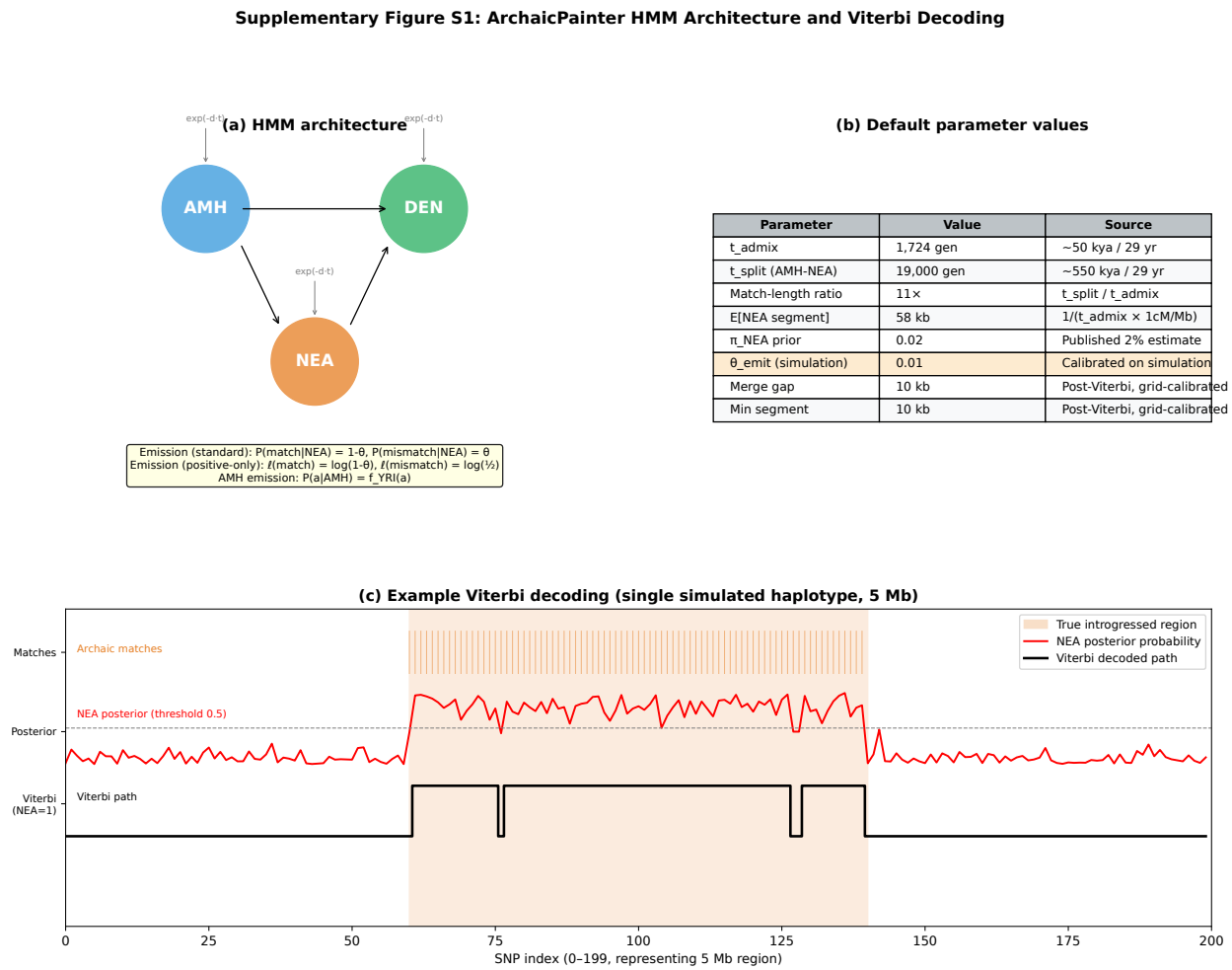
Supplementary Figure S1: ArchaicPainter HMM architecture and Viterbi decoding

Supplementary Figure S2: Three-state Neanderthal/Denisovan source attribution



Parameter	Value	Source
t_admix	1,724 gen	~50 kya / 29 yr
t_split (AMH-NEA)	19,000 gen	~550 kya / 29 yr
Match-length ratio	11×	t_split / t_admix
E[NEA segment]	58 kb	1/(t_admix × 1cM/Mb)
π_NEA prior	0.02	Published 2% estimate
θ_emit (simulation)	0.01	Calibrated on simulation
Merge gap	10 kb	Post-Viterbi, grid-calibrated
Min segment	10 kb	Post-Viterbi, grid-calibrated

Figure 6: **ArchaicPainter HMM architecture and example Viterbi decoding. (a)** Three-state HMM with states AMH (blue), NEA (orange), and DEN (green). Transition probabilities follow $\exp(-d \cdot t)$ where d is the recombination distance in Morgans and t is the admixture time in generations. Emission models are shown for both the standard bidirectional mode (simulation, where the reference matches the true donor) and the positive-only log-score mode (real data, where reference–donor divergence requires down-weighting mismatch evidence; see main text). **(b)** Default HMM parameter values with biological justifications. Core HMM parameters (t_{admix}, t_{split}, π_{NEA}, θ_{emit}) are derived from published coalescent theory; post-processing thresholds (merge gap, min segment) are calibrated by grid search on simulation to maximise F1. **(c)** Example Viterbi decoding output on a single simulated haplotype (seed 42, 5 Mb region, 2% Neanderthal admixture). The true introgressed segment (SNPs 60–140, orange shading) generates a dense cluster of archaic reference matches (top track, orange bars), which translates into elevated NEA posterior probability (middle track, red curve), and is correctly captured by the Viterbi path (bottom track, black step function, SNPs 55–145). The slight over-extension of the Viterbi path relative to the true segment reflects the 10-kb gap-merging post-processing step.

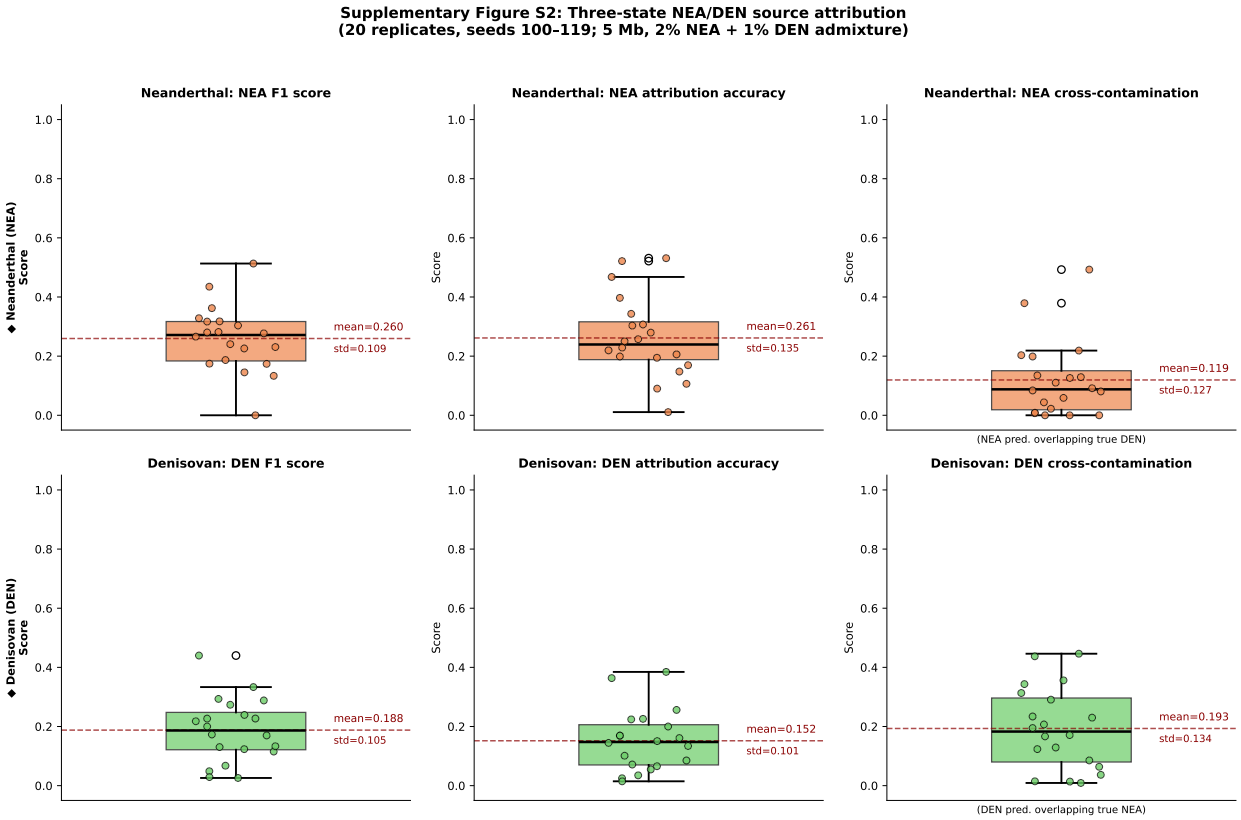


Figure 7: **Three-state ArchaicPainter source attribution results on two-source simulation (20 replicates, seeds 100–119).** Simulation demography: 5 Mb region, 2% Neanderthal (NEA) + 1% Denisovan (DEN) simultaneous admixture, matched simulated archaic reference panels. **Top row (orange)**: NEA segment-level F1 score (mean 0.260 ± 0.109), NEA source attribution accuracy (mean $26.1\% \pm 13.5\%$), and NEA-to-DEN cross-contamination rate (fraction of NEA predictions overlapping true DEN regions; mean 11.9%). **Bottom row (green)**: DEN F1 score (mean 0.188 ± 0.105), DEN attribution accuracy (mean $15.2\% \pm 10.1\%$), and DEN-to-NEA cross-contamination (mean 19.3%). Attribution accuracies above chance (>10% for both sources) confirm that the three-state HMM extracts lineage-discriminating information from the available archaic-lineage-specific alleles, despite the limited NEA–DEN divergence (∼700 kya; Prüfer et al. 2014). Box plots show median and IQR; points show individual replicates; dashed red line indicates mean.